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# Reconstructing Early Red Cross Communication Networks: LLM-Assisted Analysis of the *Bulletin International* (1884–1914)

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## Abstract

Despite its central role as one of the main communication infrastructures of the early Red Cross Movement, the *Bulletin International des Sociétés de la Croix-Rouge* has rarely been examined systematically as a source for reconstructing transnational communication among national societies (*International Review of the Red Cross* 2018). Published with a relatively stable editorial structure, the 180 processed issues up to 1914 constitute a coherent serial corpus for analysing information circulation, documentary selection, and the emergence of organizational hierarchies comparable to those observed in other international bodies (**Grandjean 2017**). The central argument of this paper is that the *Bulletin* did not simply record Red Cross activities, but actively organized, compared, and circulated humanitarian knowledge before the First World War.

The paper models the co-occurrence of people, institutions, places, concepts, documents, publications, and events within the *Bulletin* as a historical network capable of revealing communication asymmetries, editorial priorities, and evolving transnational relations. Rather than treating the periodical as a repository of information, the analysis approaches it as a documentary on, and network visualization. Recent advances in OCR post-correction and named-entity recognition for historical documents provide an important methodological background (**Greif, Griesshaber, and Greif 2025**), while current debates on model design bias and multilingual extraction inform the critical supervision of the pipeline (**Oberbichler et al. 2026**). A key methodological choice is to preserve the textual unit of evidence: relations are not extracted as free-floating links but remain connected to the paragraph or factoid from which they derive (**Bradley and Short 2005**). This makes the resulting graphs inspectable and historically controllable. The completed processing of the corpus makes it possible to compare several levels of transformation: scanned source pages, OCR text, structured factoid JSON, triples, nodes, edges, and Gephi visualizations. The visual material accompanying the paper illustrates this passage from source to data and from raw extraction to cleaned, filtered networks. Instead of privileging only the densest and least legible areas of the graph, selected close-ups highlight analytically meaningful clusters (persons, concepts, publications, and documentary forms) where the structure of the *Bulletin*'s communication system becomes easier to interpret. These clusters suggest that administrative, legal-documentary, medical-relief, geographic, chronological, and conference-related vocabularies were not isolated domains, but interconnected registers mediated by recurrent nodes such as committees, societies, reports, conventions, bulletins, and conferences.

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The findings remain preliminary: processing the full corpus does not mean that entity disambiguation, multilingual variation, implicit references, OCR instability, and relation overproduction have been fully resolved. Nevertheless, the results show that LLM-assisted historical network analysis, when embedded in a supervised and source-critical workflow, can reconstruct early humanitarian communication networks in ways that are scalable, inspectable, and historically meaningful. More broadly, the *Bulletin International* functioned as a boundary object between otherwise heterogeneous national committees (**Star and Griesemer 1989**). As a periodical circulating across distinct linguistic, legal, and institutional contexts, it provided a shared documentary form that different actors could interpret according to their own local needs while still contributing to a recognizable transnational whole.

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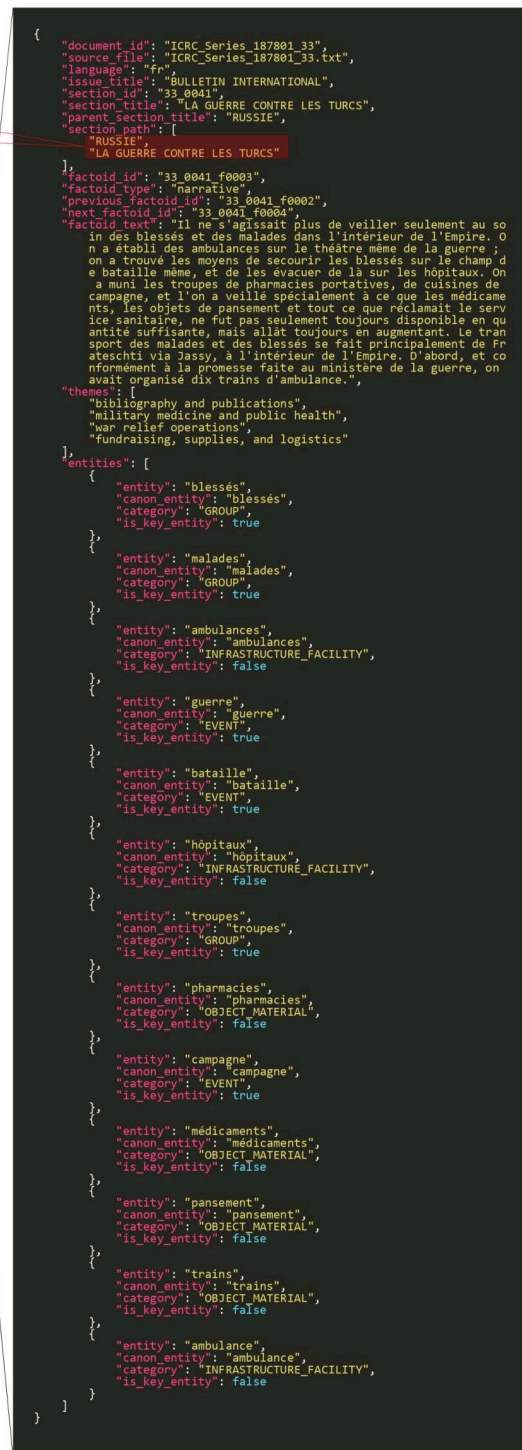
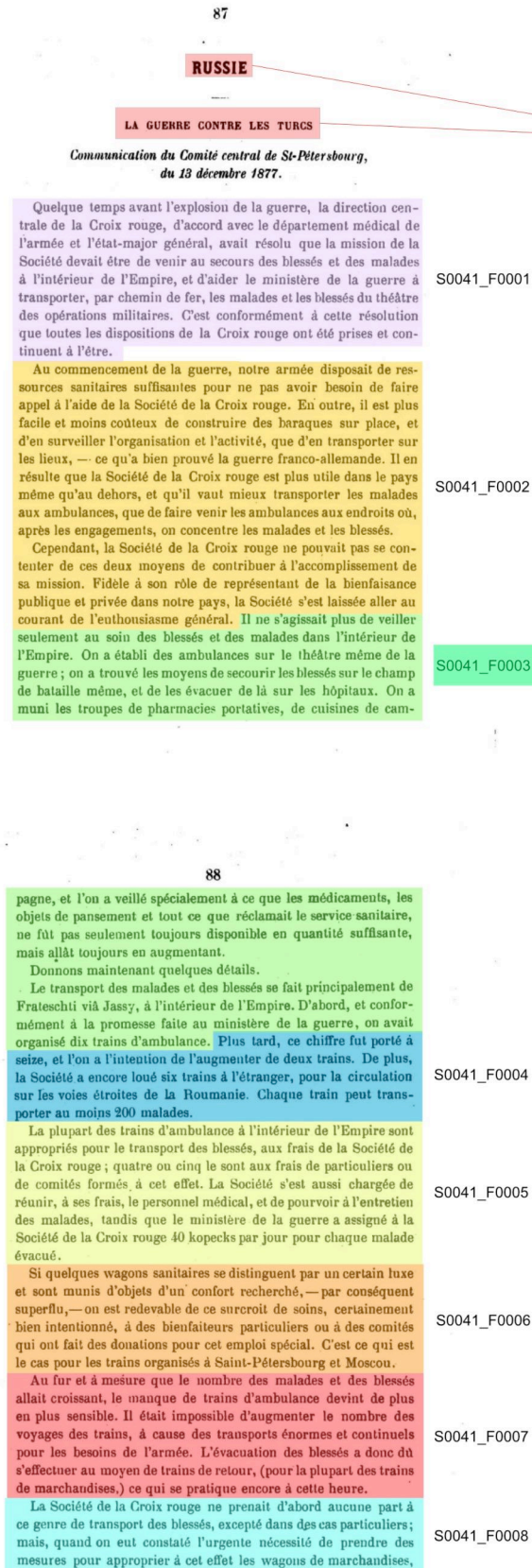
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**Keywords:** Red Cross, Bulletin International, historical networks, semantic network analysis, LLM assisted extraction, OCR post correction, named entity recognition, digital archives, data modelling, transnational communication

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**[FIG. 1]** A digitized pages of the *Bulletin International* is segmented into sequential textual units, each identified by a unique code. One selected segment is represented in JSON format, preserving documentary metadata, normalized text, thematic tags, and extracted entities. Categories are assigned according to both lexical form and contextual function within the factoid.



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